

Appendix A — Band descriptor summary tables

Everything below is paraphrase. No official grid is reproduced here, and no cell is a transcription of one. Where a phrase is short enough and load-bearing enough that the chapters already quote it, it appears in quotation marks and nowhere else. If you want the official wording, you must download the official file — and you should, once, end to end.

Where the current files live, and what edition you must have:

File	Current edition	Pages
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-band-descriptors.pdf	created 3 May 2023	9
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-speaking-band-descriptors.pdf	created 16 September 2025	4
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-key-assessment-criteria.pdf	companion prose — defines each criterion	—
ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-speaking-key-assessment-criteria.pdf	companion prose (2023)	—

[src: ielts.org — Understanding IELTS scoring; PDF metadata read directly, 31 July 2026]

The Speaking file is **two years newer than the Writing file**, and that catches people out. Two superseded PDFs — a 2-page Writing file last modified June 2013 and a 1-page Speaking file created 2008 — still outrank the current ones in search. Count the pages before you trust a descriptor PDF: current Writing is 9, current Speaking is 4. Appendix E has the full identification procedure.

Three rules for reading any of these tables:

1. A script must **fully fit a band's positive features to be rated there**. Half-fitting band 7 is a 6.
2. **Bold, in the official grid, marks a negative feature that limits the rating**. On the Task 1 bands 6/5/4 page there is exactly **one** bolded clause, and it is in the band-5 Task Achievement row. On the Task 2 bands 6/5/4 page there are exactly **two**, and both are in the **band-5** rows — Task Response and Coherence & Cohesion. **Nothing at band 6 is bolded**. Band 6 does not cap

you with a named negative; it caps you by describing what you are, positively, and by your failure to fully fit band 7. [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Writing band descriptors (PDF, Updated May 2023)]

3. **The four criteria are equally weighted**, and the task score is their average [src: ielts.org — Understanding and setting IELTS scores].

On band 9. The chapters' decoders run 8 down to 5, deliberately: band 5 is where an undiagnosed first drill can land and band 9 is not a working target. Band 9 is included here only so the scale is complete. Read it once and never again.

These tables are a summary. Every criterion below has a worked **X/√** pair — your sentence at band 6, the same sentence at band 7 — in the chapter decoder it comes from. The summary tells you where you are; the chapter tells you what to do about it.

A.1 — Writing Task 1

Source of the paraphrases: *Chapter 4 §Band descriptor decoder, from the May 2023 grid, pp. 3–5.*

Task Achievement

Band	What it takes
9	Every requirement of the task met in full; the answer is completely developed.
8	All requirements covered appropriately, relevantly and in depth. Key features selected skilfully, made prominent, and illustrated. Occasional omissions tolerated.
7	Requirements covered; content relevant and accurate with at most a few omissions; the format is right; the features you chose are clearly foregrounded, though they could be illustrated further. For Academic: a clear overview, " the data are appropriately categorised ", and the main trends or differences named .
6	Focused on the task, format appropriate, features given adequate prominence, information selected and supported with figures, and an overview <i>attempted</i> and relevant. But some detail may be irrelevant, inappropriate or inaccurate, and some may be missing or excessive.
5	Requirements <i>generally</i> addressed; format may be inappropriate in places. Selected key features are not adequately covered; the recounting of detail is mainly mechanical; a tendency to report details without referring to the bigger picture; irrelevant or inaccurate material in key areas detracts. Bolded negative on this row: there may be no data supporting the description.

The 6→7 gate, three things, all required: the overview must be *clear*, not merely attempted · the data must be **categorised** · the main trends or differences must be **named**, not left for the reader to infer. A perfect list is a band-6 answer.

Coherence & Cohesion

Band	What it takes
9	The message is followed effortlessly; cohesion is handled so well that it very rarely draws attention to itself; paragraphing is skilful.

Band	What it takes
8	The message can be followed with ease . Information and ideas logically presented and sequenced; cohesion well managed; paragraphing sufficient and appropriate. Occasional lapses allowed.
7	Logical organisation and clear progression throughout , with at most a few lapses. A range of cohesive devices — including reference and substitution — used flexibly, though with some inaccuracy or some over- or under-use.
6	Generally coherent, progression clear, devices working to some good effect — but cohesion within or between sentences may be faulty or mechanical , and reference and substitution may lack flexibility, producing repetition or error.
5	Organisation is evident but not wholly logical, and overall progression may be lacking, though an underlying coherence survives. Sentences are not fluently linked to each other. Cohesive devices limited or overused, with some inaccuracy; writing may be repetitive because reference and substitution are inadequate or inaccurate.

The 6→7 gate, two moves, and nobody makes the second: stop bolting a connector onto every sentence · **use reference and substitution**, which band 7 names by name. 5→6 is not about linker count: at 6 the progression is *clear*, at 5 it is merely *underlying*.

Lexical Resource

Band	What it takes
9	Full flexibility and precise use across a wide resource; lexical features handled with complete naturalness; the only errors are rare slips.
8	A wide resource used fluently and flexibly for precise meaning within the scope of the task; uncommon and idiomatic items handled skilfully; occasional inaccuracy.
7	Resource sufficient for some flexibility and precision; some ability with less common items; " an awareness of style and collocation is evident ", though inappropriacies occur; a few spelling or word-formation errors that do not detract.
6	Generally adequate and appropriate; meaning clear despite a fairly restricted range or imprecise word choice. A risk-taker shows more range but more inaccuracy . Some spelling and word-formation errors that do not impede.
5	The resource is limited but minimally adequate ; simple vocabulary may be accurate but the range does not permit much variation; frequent lapses in appropriacy of word choice; inflexibility showing as frequent simplification or repetition. Spelling and word-formation errors may be noticeable and may cause the reader some difficulty .

The 6→7 gate: precision and collocation, not rarity. Note the scope hedge the 2023 wording adds at bands 7–9 — precision is judged *within the scope of the task*, and Task 1's field is narrow. 5→6 is the *impeding* line: at 6 the errors do not impede; at 5 they cause the reader difficulty.

Spelling and word formation are scored here, under Lexical Resource — not under Grammar

[src: ielts.org — IELTS Writing key assessment criteria (PDF)]. For a French/Arabic L1 writer whose misspellings are predictable, that concentrates the damage on one criterion.

Grammatical Range & Accuracy

Band	What it takes
9	A wide range of structures used with complete flexibility and control; punctuation and grammar right throughout; errors rare enough to read as slips.
8	A wide range of structures within the scope of the task, used flexibly and accurately; most sentences error-free; punctuation well handled.
7	A variety of complex structures with some flexibility and accuracy; grammar and punctuation generally well controlled and "error-free sentences are frequent" ; a few errors that do not impede communication.
6	A mix of simple and complex forms, limited flexibility, and complex structures noticeably less accurate than simple ones ; errors occur but rarely impede.
5	The range is limited and rather repetitive . Complex sentences are <i>attempted</i> but tend to be faulty , and the greatest accuracy is on simple ones. Grammatical errors may be frequent and cause the reader some difficulty ; punctuation may be faulty.

Read 5, 6 and 7 as one ladder: at 5 your complex sentences are *faulty*; at 6 they are *less accurate than your simple ones*; at 7 they are as accurate as your simple ones. The fix is never more complexity — it is complexity you can control.

Punctuation is inside GRA. A comma splice is a grammar error.

A.2 — Writing Task 2

Source of the paraphrases: Chapter 5 §Band descriptor decoder, from the May 2023 grid, pp. 7–9.

Coherence & Cohesion, Lexical Resource and Grammatical Range & Accuracy are worded identically to Task 1 in the official grid — the differences below are in emphasis and in the examples the chapters attach, not in the criterion.

Task Response

Band	What it takes
9	The prompt is addressed fully and explored in depth; the position is clear and fully developed throughout; ideas are relevant, fully extended and well supported.
8	The prompt is addressed appropriately <i>and sufficiently</i> . Position clear and well developed. Ideas relevant, well extended, well supported. Only occasional omissions or lapses in content.
7	The main parts are addressed appropriately. "A clear and developed position" is presented. Main ideas are extended and supported — but there may be a tendency to over-generalise, or supporting material may lack focus and precision.
6	The main parts are addressed, but some more fully than others . Format appropriate. Position relevant, yet conclusions may be unclear, unjustified or repetitive. Main ideas relevant but some underdeveloped; some support weak or less relevant.
5	The main parts of the prompt are incompletely addressed (<i>bolded negative</i>); format may be inappropriate in places. A position is expressed but its development is not always clear. Main ideas are limited and insufficiently developed; there may be irrelevant detail or repetition.

Unevenness costs you the 7; absence costs you the 6. Band 6 tolerates uneven coverage; band 5 is where a part is left incomplete. And ielts.org states the two-part case in its own words: "*If you don't discuss both, you will be limited to Band 5.*" [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources, verbatim, fetched 2026-07-31]

6 → 7 in one line: at 6, ideas are *stated*; at 7, ideas are *extended and supported*.

A correction most books get wrong. The 2013 edition said band 7 presents a clear position *throughout*. The **2023 edition does not** — band 7 now reads simply that a clear and developed position is presented. *Throughout* survives at band 9 and, usefully, in **Coherence & Cohesion at band 7**. So "hold your position throughout" is still right advice; its descriptor home has moved.

Under-length has no published tariff. There is no arithmetic deduction anywhere in the May 2023 grid. Shortfall is marked *through* the criteria: Task Response is defined as fulfilling the task using the stated minimum, so a short answer cannot have fully addressed the prompt, and there is too little text to evidence lexical or grammatical range. The one hard rule: **a response of 20 words or fewer is rated band 1**. Copied rubric is discounted *before* the count is taken.

Coherence & Cohesion

Band	What it takes
9	The message is followed effortlessly; cohesion very rarely draws attention; paragraphing skilful.
8	Message followed with ease; ideas logically sequenced; cohesion well managed; occasional lapses; paragraphing sufficient and appropriate.
7	Logically organised with clear progression throughout , a few minor lapses allowed. A range of cohesive devices <i>including reference and substitution</i> used flexibly, though with inaccuracies or " some over/under use ". Paragraphing generally effective; sequencing within paragraphs generally logical.
6	Generally coherent with clear overall progression. Devices work to some good effect, but cohesion within or between sentences may be faulty or mechanical through misuse, overuse or omission. Reference and substitution may lack flexibility. Paragraphing may not always be logical.
5	Organisation evident but not wholly logical; overall progression may be lacking. Sentences not fluently linked . Devices limited or overused with inaccuracy; repetition through inadequate or inaccurate reference and substitution. " Paragraphing may be inadequate or missing " (<i>bolded negative</i>).

Nothing in the grid rewards quantity of linkers. Over-use is named at band 7 and again at band 6. Officially, cohesive devices come in three families — logical connectors, conjunctions, and pronouns/reference — and reference and substitution are the two band 7 asks for by name

[src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF), p.3; descriptors PDF, p.7]. About **two markers per paragraph, never zero**: one official script was docked for overuse, another for under-use.

The cheapest band in this book to protect: four or five paragraphs with a blank line between them, decided before you start writing.

Lexical Resource

Band	What it takes
9	Full flexibility and precise use; lexical features handled with complete naturalness; only rare slips.
8	Wide resource used fluently and flexibly for precise meaning; skilful use of uncommon and idiomatic items despite occasional inaccuracy; occasional spelling or word-formation errors with minimal impact.
7	Resource sufficient for some flexibility and precision. Some ability with less common and idiomatic items. "An awareness of style and collocation" is evident, though inappropriacies occur. Only a few spelling or word-formation errors, and they do not detract from clarity.
6	Generally adequate and appropriate. Meaning generally clear despite a rather restricted range or a lack of precision. A risk-taker will show wider vocabulary but with higher inaccuracy. Some spelling or word-formation errors, but they do not impede.
5	Resource limited but minimally adequate ; simple vocabulary may be accurate but the range does not permit much variation. Frequent lapses in appropriacy; inflexibility showing as frequent simplification or repetition. Spelling and word-formation errors may be noticeable and may cause the reader some difficulty .

Read the band-6 risk-taker clause twice. The descriptor explicitly anticipates the thesaurus strategy and places it *at band 6*. Reaching for rare words without collocation control is a band-6 behaviour by definition, not an ambitious one.

6 → 7 in one line: at 6 the word is understandable; at 7 it is the right word and it keeps the company it normally keeps.

"Idiomatic", in descriptor sense, means natural collocation (*strike a balance*), not figurative idiom (*rain cats and dogs*). In Writing the first raises LR and the second lowers it on register.

Grammatical Range & Accuracy

Band	What it takes
9	Wide range with complete flexibility and control; punctuation and structure right throughout; errors rare enough to read as slips.
8	A wide range used flexibly and accurately. The majority of sentences are error-free; punctuation well managed. Occasional, non-systematic errors with minimal impact.
7	A variety of complex structures used with some flexibility and accuracy. Grammar and punctuation generally well controlled, and "error-free sentences are frequent" . A few errors persist but do not impede.
6	A mix of simple and complex forms with limited flexibility. Complex structures are less accurate than the simple ones. Errors occur but rarely impede.
5	Range limited and rather repetitive . Complex sentences <i>attempted</i> but tend to be faulty ; greatest accuracy on simple sentences. Grammatical errors may be frequent and cause the reader some difficulty ; punctuation may be faulty.

The derived working proxy, and it is derived — not published. Band 7 needs error-free sentences to be *frequent*; band 8 needs them to be *the majority*. No official source quantifies *frequent*, so band 7 must sit **below** a majority. Working number: **four sentences in ten completely clean, rising to five**. On a 280-word essay of about sixteen sentences — fewer than six clean and you are arguing for a 6; six to eight is band-7 territory; nine or ten is an argument for 8. [Chapter 8](#) §How accurate is "accurate enough"? owns the derivation.

What "complex" officially means at band 7 and above: passive constructions, modal verbs, comparative forms and complex noun phrases — **not merely subordinate clauses** [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources].

Systematic versus non-systematic decides band 8: a repeated article error across the whole script is systematic and blocks band 8; three unrelated slips are not [src: same]. For an Arabic/French L1 writer that is decisive — article errors are the archetypal systematic error.

Combining the two tasks

The **ratio is official**: Task 1 is worth a third of the Writing mark and Task 2 two thirds [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources]; equivalently, Task 2 contributes twice as much as Task 1 [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Writing test format]. The **arithmetic is not published**:

Planning estimate, not IELTS's method: Writing band $\approx (\text{Task 1 band} + 2 \times \text{Task 2 band}) \div 3$

Never present a number it produces as the score IELTS would compute.

A.3 — Speaking

Source of the paraphrases: [Chapter 6](#) §Band descriptor decoder, from the 2025 Speaking grid, with operational definitions from the 2023 key assessment criteria. If a guide you are reading describes band 6 Pronunciation without mentioning chunking, stress-timing or speech rate, it is quoting the 2008/2013 file — close it.

Fluency & Coherence

Band	What it takes
9	Talks at length with only very occasional repetition or self-correction; any hesitation is about what to say , not how to say it; topics fully and appropriately developed.
8	Fluent, only occasional repetition or self-correction. Hesitation may still occasionally be for language, but most is about content . Topic development coherent, appropriate, relevant.
7	Keeps going, readily produces long turns, no visible effort. Hesitation, repetition and self-correction occur, often mid-sentence , and do signal difficulty reaching the right language — but <i>"these will not affect coherence."</i> Markers, connectives and cohesive features used flexibly .
6	Keeps going, willing to produce long turns. Coherence is lost at times through hesitation, repetition or self-correction. Uses a range of markers, but not always appropriately.

Band	What it takes
5	Usually able to keep going, but relies on repetition and self-correction to do so, and/or on slow speech . Hesitations are often mid-sentence searches for fairly basic lexis and grammar. Overuse of certain discourse markers. More complex speech usually causes disfluency.

The 6→7 jump is coherence survival, not silence. Band 7 still hesitates and still hesitates *for language*. The trainable skill is **sentence recovery**: hold the structure and finish it. Hesitating about *content* is band 8, not band 7 — a claim that circulates widely in the other direction and is wrong.

Slow speech is a band-5 limiter on this criterion, while a **rapid** rate wrecks rhythm on Pronunciation. They bracket the target: the instruction is **measured**.

Lexical Resource

Band	What it takes
9	Full flexibility and precision on every topic; idiomatic language produced naturally and accurately.
8	Wide resource, used readily and flexibly across all topics for precise meaning. Skilful use of less common and idiomatic items despite occasional slips. Paraphrases effectively.
7	Used flexibly across a variety of topics. Some ability with less common and idiomatic items; awareness of style and collocation visible, though inappropriate choices occur. " <i>Effective use of paraphrase as required.</i> "
6	Sufficient to discuss topics at length. Word choice may be inappropriate, but meaning comes through. Generally able to paraphrase.
5	Resource sufficient to discuss familiar <i>and</i> unfamiliar topics, but with limited flexibility . Paraphrase is <i>attempted</i> but not always with success .

The 5→6→7 ladder on this criterion is entirely about paraphrase — attempted at 5, generally successful at 6, effective as required at 7. So the drill is rerouting round a missing word, not learning more words. Paraphrase is credited **with or without noticeable hesitation**: groping audibly toward the words and getting there still counts. Not knowing a word is not the problem. Going silent is.

Unlike Writing, idioms are officially encouraged in Speaking.

Grammatical Range & Accuracy

Band	What it takes
9	Full range of structures produced naturally and appropriately; errors so rare they read as slips.
8	Wide range of structures, flexibly used; majority of sentences error-free. Occasional inappropriacies, non-systematic errors. A few basic errors may persist.
7	A range of structures used flexibly. " <i>Error-free sentences are frequent.</i> " Both simple and complex sentences used effectively despite some errors. A few basic errors persist.
6	A mix of short and complex sentence forms and a variety of structures, with limited flexibility. Errors frequent in complex structures, though they rarely block communication.

Band	What it takes
5	Basic sentence forms fairly well controlled. Complex structures attempted, but limited in range, nearly always containing errors, and may lead to the need for reformulation.

Read the quantifier, not just the permission. Band 7 does *not* demand that you eliminate article errors or missing third-person -s — those are precisely the basic errors permitted at 7. It demands there be only **a few** of them. That is a density claim, and the official criteria rate accuracy on exactly that: "*error density (the number of grammatical errors in a given amount of speech)*" [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. Omitting -s seven times in ten obligatory contexts is not exploiting a tolerance; it is producing the band-6 measurement.

The 2025 range clause no longer says "complex structures." It says a range of structures, and explicitly credits **simple sentences used effectively**.

Drill six, in this order: second and third conditionals · concessives (*although, whereas*) · non-defining relatives (*which in turn*) · present perfect for change over time · the passive for generalisation (*it's often argued that*) · modality (*might well, would have to, is bound to*).

Pronunciation

Band	What it takes
9	Full range of phonological features used with precision and subtlety; flexibility sustained throughout; effortless to understand.
8	Wide range of features conveying precise and subtle meaning. Can sustain appropriate rhythm. Flexible stress and intonation across long utterances, occasional lapses. Easy to understand throughout. Accent has minimal effect on intelligibility.
7	Defined only by reference to its neighbours: all the positive features of band 6, plus some — not all — of band 8.
6	Uses a range of features, but control is variable . Chunking generally appropriate, but " <i>rhythm may be affected by a lack of stress-timing and/or a rapid speech rate.</i> " Some effective use of intonation and stress, not sustained. Individual words or phonemes may be mispronounced, causing occasional lack of clarity. Can generally be understood throughout without much effort.
5	Defined only by reference to its neighbours, exactly as band 7 is: all the positive features of band 4, plus some — not all — of band 6.

Bands 5 and 7 have no positive features of their own. That is not a drafting accident; it is the instruction. To reach 7: **secure every band-6 feature outright, then buy some band-8 features.** Band 8 lists five; *some* of five is not one. **Budget for two — sustained rhythm** first, because it is a motor habit, then **flexible stress and intonation across long utterances**, which the same drills give you.

Pronunciation is 25% of the Speaking band, exactly as much as grammar. It is a trainable quarter, not a fixed accent tax. **Accent is never rated in itself**, only through its effect on intelligibility — and it does not appear at bands 6 or 7 at all.

A.4 — What the objective papers have instead

Listening and Reading have no band descriptors. None exist and none are being withheld.

Any site offering "IELTS Listening band descriptors" is showing a raw-score conversion table under a misleading title. What they have is arithmetic:

Band	Listening (/40)	Academic Reading (/40)
9	39–40	39–40
8.5	37–38	37–38
8	35–36	35–36
7.5	32–34	33–34
7	30–31	30–32
6.5	26–29	27–29
6	23–25	23–26
5.5	18–22	19–22
5	16–17	15–18

[src: ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening — IELTS Listening band scores; the table is on IDP's market pages, not the canonical /results/scores/listening URL] [src: ielts.idp.com — Reading band scores]

This is published, not reconstructed. ielts.org and the British Council publish four anchor points per paper — Listening **16/23/30/35**, Academic Reading **15/23/30/35** — and every one of them is the bottom mark of the corresponding IDP row. The two tables agree exactly [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained].

Both carry the same caveat, and so should you: these are the **average** marks required, and actual marks vary slightly between test versions. Plan against the *top* of the band you are targeting, never its floor.

Note the two asymmetries: the band-5 anchor differs (Reading **15**, Listening **16**), and the *ranges* differ even where the anchors match — a raw 26 is 6.5 in Listening and still 6 in Reading; a raw 32 is 7.5 in Listening and still 7 in Reading. **Score each paper against its own column.**

A.5 — The overall band

Average the four section bands and round to the nearest half band. **.25 rounds up to the next half band; .75 rounds up to the next whole band** [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained].

Which is why **6.75 reports as 7.0** — a total of **27.0 out of 28.0**. From a 6.5 floor in all four papers you have 26.0, so you need exactly **two more half-bands**, not four sevens. **Chapter 1** §The strategic core has the route table. Buy a third half-band if you can: 27.0 exactly has zero margin.

One qualifier overrides all of it: a per-section minimum is a gate, not an average. A script can report 6.5 overall and still fail a Writing 6.5 requirement.